



Short videos as affective contagion: (Un)locked WeChat chatlogs on viral videos

Ge Zhang

To cite this article: Ge Zhang (2022): Short videos as affective contagion: (Un)locked WeChat chatlogs on viral videos, Visual Studies, DOI: [10.1080/1472586X.2022.2070537](https://doi.org/10.1080/1472586X.2022.2070537)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1080/1472586X.2022.2070537>



Published online: 17 May 2022.



Submit your article to this journal [↗](#)



View related articles [↗](#)



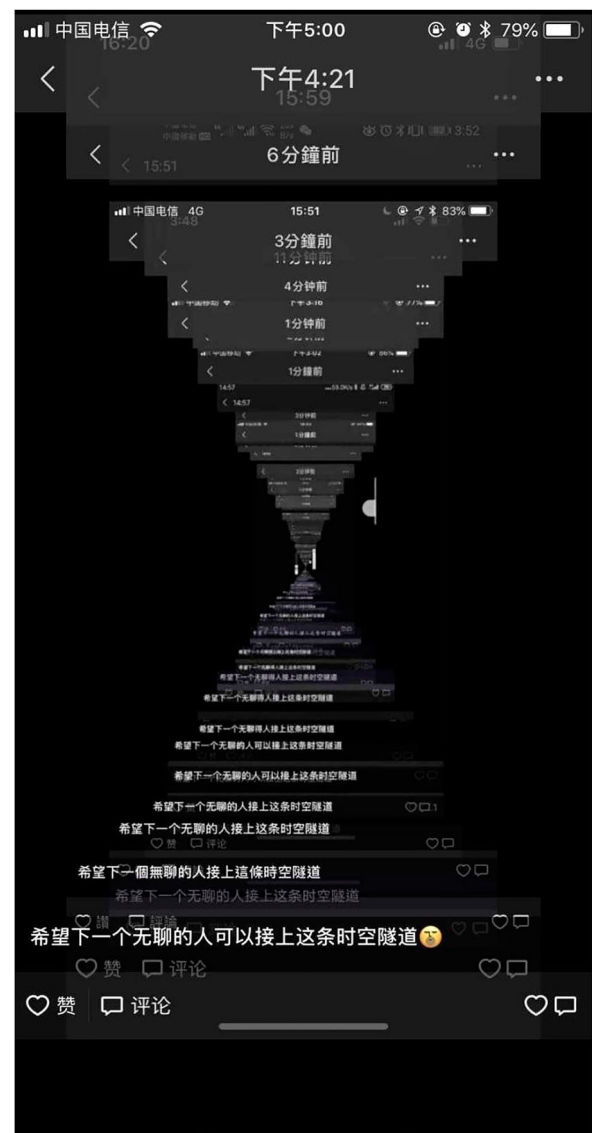
View Crossmark data [↗](#)

Short videos as affective contagion: (Un)locked WeChat chatlogs on viral videos

This visual essay is a documentation of a series of morbid short videos circulating in local Wuhan chat groups at the beginning of the COVID-19 pandemic, attached with video screenshots and adjacent chatlogs. The data was collected during the author's home quarantine in Wuhan in early 2020. This visual essay aims at viscerally exhibiting the circulation of emotions ranging from anxiety to boredom to lethargy via group conversations surrounding these short videos. Hopefully, they can serve as an archive and a miniature of a societal meltdown that is readily forgotten.

‘Spatio-temporal Tunnel’

The image depicts a screenshot of a screenshot of a screenshot of ... a screenshot of a black image with the caption 'hope the next bored person can be connected to this spatiotemporal tunnel [emm speechless Emoji]'



PATCHWORK (AUTO)ETHNOGRAPHY OF A WECHAT GROUP

Since January 2020, a series of unfortunate circumstances culminated in me being stuck at home for 69 days during the Wuhan lockdown. I was glued to my phone like everyone else, checking the latest updates of lockdown measures, booking grocery delivery days in advance, negotiating with the local cadres and neighbours for group buying and other supermarket deliveries, and doomscrolling the Moments timeline (a built-in feed of status updates, pictures and videos) – all of which took place on WeChat. A week before, WeChat was just an object for/of my ongoing ethnographic research; I didn't have a bank account associated with WeChat and I had never used the app for anything other than instant messaging despite its plethora of very 'sticky' built-in functions (Chen, Mao, and Qiu 2018). WeChat group chats, which were already under strict regulations since 2017 (Yang 2017), soon re-emerged as a whirlpool of viral emotions, ranging from pulsations of anxiety to outbursts of solidarity and everything in-between, intersecting with and stacking upon the infected cases surging in the city. Most of the time, apart from helpful pragmatic information, the group chats became an epidemiological space of circulating short videos as well as negotiating affective fluctuations.

At the beginning of the lockdown, I was invited to a group chat between a small group of acquaintances and friends of friends (11 heterosexual male Wuhan locals in their late 20s and 30s; I was invited by a mutual friend of the administrator of the group) due to the dire need of information in a time of total disorientation. Overwhelmed by a flood of morbid short videos circulated in this group chat, I could not help but continue documenting, archiving the chatlogs, and adding notes as if this were my escape route. I managed to convince myself that this daily work of participating and following group chats was an involuntary but nonetheless bearable fieldwork. In this way, I could somehow alienate myself from the acute stress, in the name of my disciplinary tenacity. What was therapeutic in my case was not writing an (auto)ethnography introspectively – 'he is engaged in saving his own, by a curious and ambitious act of intellectual catharsis' (Sontag 2009, 75) – but going into a 'fieldwork mode' mentality.

As a direct witness and participant of the first Covid-19 lockdown, many colleagues and friends encouraged me to write commentaries since February 2020. But I was so incompetently haunted by the danger of becoming 'the nightmarish figure of the uselessly and continuously commenting academic' (Hage 2020, 664) that I refrained from producing and publishing any timely writings out of my miseries until a year after. This visual essay is not

only untimely in terms of publication date but also how lockdowns or home quarantines have become a quotidianized norm to various degrees around the world. This exact untimeliness can be cultivated ethnographically (Rabinow and Marcus 2008) as a specific relevance – in my case, how people coped with ugly emotions in a WeChat group – rather than a generic relevance that builds upon the event (i.e. the pandemic).

This very untimely 'patchwork ethnography' is not a result of voluntary fieldwork nor a self-centric introspection but a liminal state of somewhere in-between. Günel, Varma, and Watanabe (2020)'s call for a patchwork ethnography – different 'ethnographic processes and protocols ... using fragmentary yet rigorous data, and other innovations that resist the fixity, holism, and certainty demanded in the publication process' – came at an opportune time and 'patched' my anxiety up. Partial knowledge outside a holistic substantial monograph can help recognize inconsistencies, doubts as well as concerns, and potentially turn 'limitations and constraints into openings for new insights' (ibid). There are already many excellent autoethnographic experiments on their Covid lockdown/quarantine experiences resonating with this call (e.g. Harris and Holman Jones 2021; Zheng 2021; Lee 2021). I full-heartedly align this visual essay with these works. However, in my case, the subjective 'I' does not appear as a character in this visual essay. While my own experiences and emotions do inevitably inform and bleed into this essay, I am not the main character but this anonymized cohort of one WeChat group. The main purpose of this essay is to demonstrate how affects in group chats fluctuate according to the circulation of digital objects (in my case, short videos) via the excerpts of chatlogs and video screenshots. I hope they can serve as an archive and a miniature of a societal meltdown that is readily forgotten.

STAGE I: AFFECTIVE CONTAGION UNLEASHED: ANXIETY

20 January 2020 (Figure 1)

Y: This is how Wuhan clubbers go by. [Face with tears of joy Emoji] x 4 [We are] City of Heroes. Masked Clubbing.

S: No zuo no die why you try? [*sic*] (translation: why do you try even you know you are going to die)?

Z: I think this plague won't be stopped then. I will stay at home for the coming week and spend the Lunar New Year indoor.



FIGURE 1. Screenshot of a video in which a line of people entering a night club in Wuhan through the metal detector gate, with bouncers in face masks checking everyone's temperature with infrared thermometer guns.

Multiple videos shared on this day expressed a similar attitude of total disregard to the catastrophe looming on the horizon: a meme depicted a monk in Zen mode as the Wuhan locals ignoring warnings about 'epidemic prevention measures' such as wearing a mask. These videos and memes sent to the group chat made everyone in the group chat even more alarmed and opted to stay at home even before the official announcement of lockdown.

21 January (Figure 2)

(It was advised by the Chinese Center for Disease Control and Prevention to not visit or leave Wuhan.)

Z: The scary thing is that I have already seen every picture and video you guys shared.



FIGURE 2. Screenshot of a video in which a patient quarantined in transparent plastic tube while being transported by medical workers from an ambulance.

J: I have changed my mentality from a few days ago. I have stopped reading news and watching these videos circulated [in WeChat]. The main thing is that I am so bored being stuck at home, all social occasions have been cancelled.

Many videos regarding the still unknown coronavirus situation were shared in the group but then 'recalled' (WeChat has this function where the sender can recall the last message within 2 min of sending it) on second thoughts due to three reasons: first, to avoid the group getting flagged by censorship and cancelled, which may also get the group admin's WeChat account banned altogether; second, to suppress and 'quarantine' the already overwhelming spill-over of emotional outbursts in other larger and thus more anonymous group chats of more than 100 members; third, to check if the same



FIGURE 3. Screenshot of a video depicting an empty Jiangnan Road (usually one of the busiest areas in Wuhan) with the protagonist talking to the camera while recording: 'This is the first time I have seen [this street] this empty. This virus must be real'.

video was already sent to the group earlier, since videos flooded in and it was therefore difficult to keep track.

STAGE II: ANAESTHETIZING ANXIETY

22 January (Figure 3)

Coincidentally, this video was sent to the group chat by two members at the same time. As many videos were shared to the 'timeline' of the group chat, most videos did not directly lead to any conversations around them

as they were consumed as micro-dose of anxiety. Nobody had the mood to respond.

23 January (Figure 4)

(It was officially announced early in the morning that the city was effectively under strict lockdown. The group chat name was set to 'survive until we can leave' later in the day.)

S: I almost shed a tear while watching this.

L: Don't watch it.

Z: Don't watch it.



FIGURE 4. Screenshot of a video in which a woman was crying 'I am also in the queue' in a ward filled with queuing patients and medical staff in hazmat suits.

J: I don't dare to click on it. I am fucking scared of not being able to fall asleep.

Z: Please don't watch it no more. As I am bombarded by these videos every day, I feel psychologically worn out. I feel like the innermost core of the city's culture is shaking and it's just too heartbreaking to see a city in pain like this.

Y: Stop watching it. Come play card games then your pain will ease.

X: Stop watching it. You need to adjust yourself, calm down.

Z: Invite me [to the card game session].

Everyone was up very early on this day, and the day was mostly spent exchanging various – at the time rather vaguely articulated – lockdown measures and the spatio-temporal scale of it as well as corresponding preparations and improvisations to be made for the imminent home quarantine. In the wake of an overwhelming amount of unverifiable distressing news – forwarded chatlogs, screenshots, and Weibo links – we all tried to manage our anxiety and fear. We tried to look up the events of the 2003 SARS outbreak for ontological security but ultimately in vain. It was indeed *unprecedented* in our lifetime.

Near the end of the day, the group chat grew weary of the 'infodemic': 'an overload of information' and misinformation caused news avoidance altogether (de Bruin et al. 2021). They actively looked for distractions and avoidance of news in organizing card games via WeChat's own 'mini-programs' (applications built within WeChat). For the WeChat group members, there was little incentive to play games elsewhere such as a dedicated gaming console or PC despite having the options. J said he would not want to miss anything important sent to his mobile, so he had to stay mobile no matter how jaded he had become. WeChat and by extension mobile phones played the most indispensable role in institutionalizing *immobility*. We were not only stuck at home but also stuck with our phones.

STAGE III BOREDOM IS PATHOLOGIZED, YET AGAIN

26 January (Figure 5)

Y: haha we sent the video at the same time.

(The video was sent to the group chat by Y and S at the same time)

S: X, let's have a fight [Screaming Emoji] x 3

Y: Wtf.

X: How do you want to fight?

S: I just want to curse here to let off some steam.

S: [censored curses] x 3

Within a week of lockdown, there were already many videos trying to capture the boredom of home quarantine at the time. Similar to the cover image of this visual essay, most of these videos were trying to portray quarantine boredom via the theme of repetition. These

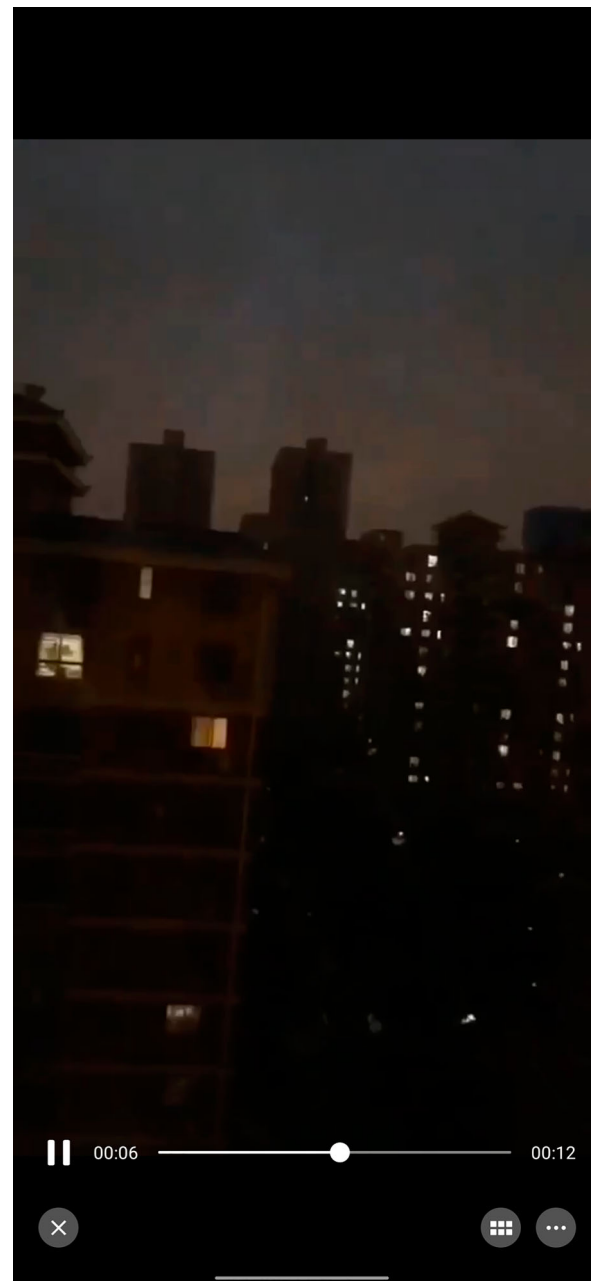


FIGURE 5. Screenshot of a video in which a bored man yelling from the confine of his window to the opposite high-rise apartment blocks: 'Is there anyone out there? Open your window! Let's have a fight!'.

short videos of micro-boredom were considered funny and provided brief distraction because they often seemed absurd in its emotional edginess on the one hand and total withdrawal on the other. But sometimes ‘micro-dosing’ short videos were not enough; even the ‘stickiness’ of WeChat was unstuck given extreme circumstances. Doctor Zhang Wenhong said during an interview on 2 February, ‘from now on everyone is a ‘solider’, your staying-at-home is no quarantine, it is combat! Do you think this is boring? The virus will be ‘bored’ to death [by your quarantine]’ (Xinhua 2020). This metaphor of war was perversely fitting because boredom is the enemy of soldiers at war (Laugesen

2012). Boredom was then pathologized as a minor symptom of home quarantine and trivialized compared to the gravity of the crisis.

STAGE IV DIGITAL DETOX DOES NOT WORK: LETHARGIC PORN

6 February (Figure 6)

(The temporary infirmaries have already begun construction across the city of Wuhan; Dr. Li Wen-liang was confirmed dead the next day)

L: I think videos like this circulating online is a good thing because people can be directly informed so we can panic less.

Y: The government does not want the infected to go around [who can’t be trusted to remain inside voluntarily] so they just quarantine them in a single administrable space.

S: What if you get infected inside this quarantine facility?

Z: Dude everyone inside the facility is supposed to be confirmed cases anyway, just not severe enough to be in ICU.

Y: Fuck this, I am going back to jerking off. Worrying about the society does not suit me. I just want to be a happy [and ignorant] man.

L: Shit there are 60 suspected cases in my residential block. I cannot breathe [due to anxiety].

Y: Go jerk off bro. Forget about the stressful things. Go straight to sleep after jerking off. Let’s talk again tomorrow. *Chong* (masturbate)!

A few moments later.

X: (Forward more videos about the temporary infirmaries) Dude a thousand people sharing a single toilet?

Z: The fuck bro, I am jerking off.

X: Sorry bro. You go on.

Z: [The video was so unsettling that] I have already lost the mood.



FIGURE 6. Screenshot of a video in which a patient recently relocated to one of the newly built temporary warehouse infirmaries explained the facilities and supplies at the infirmary such as food, toilet, and medicine.

One of the immediate distractions people sought was via pornographic videos. During the early days of the lockdown, short clips of amateur and professional porn (WeChat only allows videos under 5 min to be uploaded) were circulated not to stimulate sexual desires but to delay or relay anxiety. In the later stages of lockdown, sharing porn videos became a daily ritual that expressed not necessarily sexual seduction

– especially among heterosexual males in the case of this WeChat group – but care and solidarity in its most rudimentary sense. In S's words during a post-lockdown conversation reflecting on the experiences at the time, 'sending porn is similar to asking if someone has had dinner (a local way of saying 'how are you')'. However, sometimes snippets of porn videos did exactly the opposite of relaying anxiety and one can further submerge into total uncertainty. S confessed that he believed that masturbation could compromise his immune system, which was the only viable defense against the virus without any effective treatment at the time, but he then pondered 'what about my psychological system? There is no defense left.'

For S, porn videos and masturbation were intended to break the vicious circle of, in his words, 'the more [epidemic videos] I watch, the more frightened I am, the more I want to watch'. The mobile-centric doomscrolling led S to morbid rabbit holes of endless epidemic-related videos, not facilitated by algorithm-based apps like Tiktok but by the sheer number of videos shared to WeChat groups. Distraction via swiping on a smartphone (or masturbation in this case) became very desirable exactly because during extremely stressful times distraction could not be improvised. Just as we could only fight the symptoms of pneumonia caused by the coronavirus at the time, 'digital detox therapy only fights the symptoms' (Lovink 2019, 42) of our collective hysteria. The current pandemic put our hypothesis on the smartphone-induced 'distraction epidemic' into test. Just as Kracauer (1987) reminded us, distraction could be radical or at least 'sincere' (94) in exposing disintegration rather than hiding it within the naïve pretensions of digital detox, which 'deflect... attention away from the external damages of society onto the private individual' (ibid).

VIRALITY IS NOT A METAPHOR

Since the very beginning of lockdown, WeChat was blamed for causing an 'affective plague' (Luo 2020) or a secondary catastrophe of mental health due to the 'infodemic'. This secondary 'affective plague' spreading in WeChat's digital infrastructure was already a 'kind of network virality that surpasses linguistic categories of disease' (Sampson 2012, 3). Indeed, 'virality is not a metaphor' (Ibid, 4). WeChat was effectively an epidemiological space of both viral videos and viral emotions; 'On social media, it is affect that sets things into motion' (Karppi 2018, 18). Perhaps due to the omnicompetence of WeChat, it became synonymous

with smartphones in contemporary Chinese digital culture. When the lockdown measures gradually receded, someone in the group chat sent a picture of a propaganda banner that read 'smartphones are more harmful than coronavirus'. The whole logic of virality was exacerbated because the kinds of virality – circulating in biological and digital spaces – became literal in the most horrifying and banal way possible. If anything, the problem was not necessarily being online too much during the lockdown and not going back to the offline world enough, but rather that we were in desperate need of distractions that worked. As Miriam Rasch (cited in Lovink 2019, 43) puts it, 'don't care if it's online or offline – the two are hardly distinguishable – I care if I care, and I care about many things'.

DISCLOSURE STATEMENT

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

ORCID

Ge Zhang  <http://orcid.org/0000-0001-8317-4185>

REFERENCES

- Chen, Yujie, Zhifei Mao, and Jack Linchuan Qiu. 2018. *Super-Sticky Wechat and Chinese Society*. Bingley: Emerald Publishing.
- de Bruin, Kiki, et al. 2021. "News Avoidance During the Covid-19 Crisis: Understanding Information Overload." *Digital Journalism* 9 (9): 1–17.
- Günel, Gökçe, Saiba Varma, and Chika Watanabe. 2020. "A Manifesto for Patchwork Ethnography." *Fieldsights*, June 9. <https://culanth.org/fieldsights/a-manifesto-for-patchwork-ethnography>.
- Hage, Ghassan. 2020. "The Haunting Figure of the Useless Academic: Critical Thinking in Coronavirus Time." *European Journal of Cultural Studies* 23 (4): 662–666.
- Harris, Anne, and Stacy Holman Jones. 2021. "Massive and Microscopic: Autoethnographic Affects in the Time of COVID." *Qualitative Inquiry* 27 (7): 861–869.
- Karppi, Tero. 2018. *Disconnect: Facebook's Affective Bonds*. Minneapolis, MN: University of Minnesota Press.
- Kracauer, Siegfried. 1987. "Cult of Distraction: On Berlin's Picture Palaces." (translated by Thomas Y. Levin). *New German Critique* 40: 91–96.
- Laugesen, Amanda. 2012. *Boredom is the Enemy: The Intellectual and Imaginative Lives of Australian Soldiers in the Great War and Beyond*. Surrey, England: Ashgate.
- Lee, Sun Young. 2021. "Now as a Liminal Space, Writing as a Patchwork: Autoethnographic Reflections on the Self in the Middle of the Pandemic." *Qualitative Inquiry* 27 (7): 773–777.

- Lovink, Geert. 2019. *Sad by Design*. London: Pluto Press.
- Luo, Yu. 2020. "In the Face of a Storm, Do Not Infect Yourself with the Affective Plague." *New Weekly*, 31 Jan. https://www.thepaper.cn/newsDetail_forward_5696394.
- Rabinow, Paul, and George E Marcus. 2008. *Designs for An Anthropology of the Contemporary*. Durham: Duke University Press.
- Sampson, Tony D. 2012. *Virality: Contagion Theory in the Age of Networks*. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press.
- Sontag, Susan. 2009. *Against Interpretation and Other Essays*. London: Penguin Classics.
- Xinhua. 2020. "Zhang Wenhong: Stay at Home for Another Two Weeks, 'Bore' the Virus to Death! Your Home Quarantine is Not Quarantine but Combat!" 2 February. http://www.xinhuanet.com/politics/2020-02/06/c_1125538147.htm.
- Yang, Wanli. 2017. "Online Rules to Focus on Chat, Public Accounts." *China Daily*, 8 September. http://english.www.gov.cn/news/top_news/2017/09/08/content_281475843915377.htm.
- Zheng, Shiyu. 2021. "Quarantine Life is Stillness and Dialogue: A Reflective Autoethnography During a Global Pandemic." *Qualitative Inquiry* 27 (7): 829–834.